

KEY DATA

Size ranking 43
Brightest stars Sirius (α)
-1.5, Adhara (ε) 1.5
Genitive Canis Majoris
Abbreviation CMa
Highest in sky at 10pm
January–February
Fully visible 56°N–90°S



CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Sirius Alpha (α) Canis Majoris
Blue-white main-sequence star, also a binary
☼ -1.5 ↔ 8.6 light-years

Mirzam Beta (β) Canis Majoris
Blue giant
☼ 2.0 ↔ 492 light-years

Wezen Delta (δ) Canis Majoris
Yellow-white supergiant
☼ 1.8 ↔ 1,605 light-years

Adhara Epsilon (ε) Canis Majoris
Blue-white giant
☼ 1.5 ↔ 405 light-years

Aludra Eta (η) Canis Majoris
Blue-white supergiant
☼ 2.5 ↔ 1,985 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M41
Open star cluster

NGC 2207 and IC 2163
Two interacting galaxies

NGC 2217
Barred spiral galaxy

NGC 2359 (Thor's Helmet)
Emission nebula

NGC 2362
Open star cluster centred on Tau (τ) Canis Majoris



△ **NGC 2207 and IC 2163**
These two interacting galaxies have created a huge mask shape in space. The gravitational attraction of the larger, NGC 2207, has distorted IC 2163, flinging out stars and gas into streamers at least 100,000 light-years long. The two will continue to slowly fall closer together, forming one huge galaxy in a few billion years' time.

COLUMBA
THE DOVE

A FAINT CONSTELLATION LYING SOUTH OF LEPUS, COLUMBA WAS FORMED IN THE 16TH CENTURY FROM STARS THAT HAD NOT PREVIOUSLY BEEN ALLOCATED TO ANY OTHER CONSTELLATION.

Invented by the Dutch astronomer Petrus Plancius in 1592, Columba was originally called "Columba Noachi" in reference to the dove Noah sent out from the Ark to find dry land, in the Biblical story of the flood. In the constellation, the dove's body is marked by the star Wezn, and its head end is indicated by the yellow-orange giant Eta Columbae. Its brightest star is Phact, whose name derives from the Arabic for "collared dove." Mu Columbae is a fast-moving 5th-magnitude star that is thought to have been expelled from the Orion Nebula area. Columba's most prominent deep-sky object is globular cluster NGC 1851, visible as a faint patch through binoculars.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 54
Brightest stars Phact (α)
2.7, Wazn (β) 3.1
Genitive Columbae
Abbreviation Col
Highest in sky at 10pm
January
Fully visible 46°N–90°S



CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Phact Alpha (α) Columbae
Blue-white subgiant
☼ 2.7 ↔ 261 light-years

Wezn Beta (β) Columbae
Yellow giant
☼ 3.1 ↔ 87 light-years

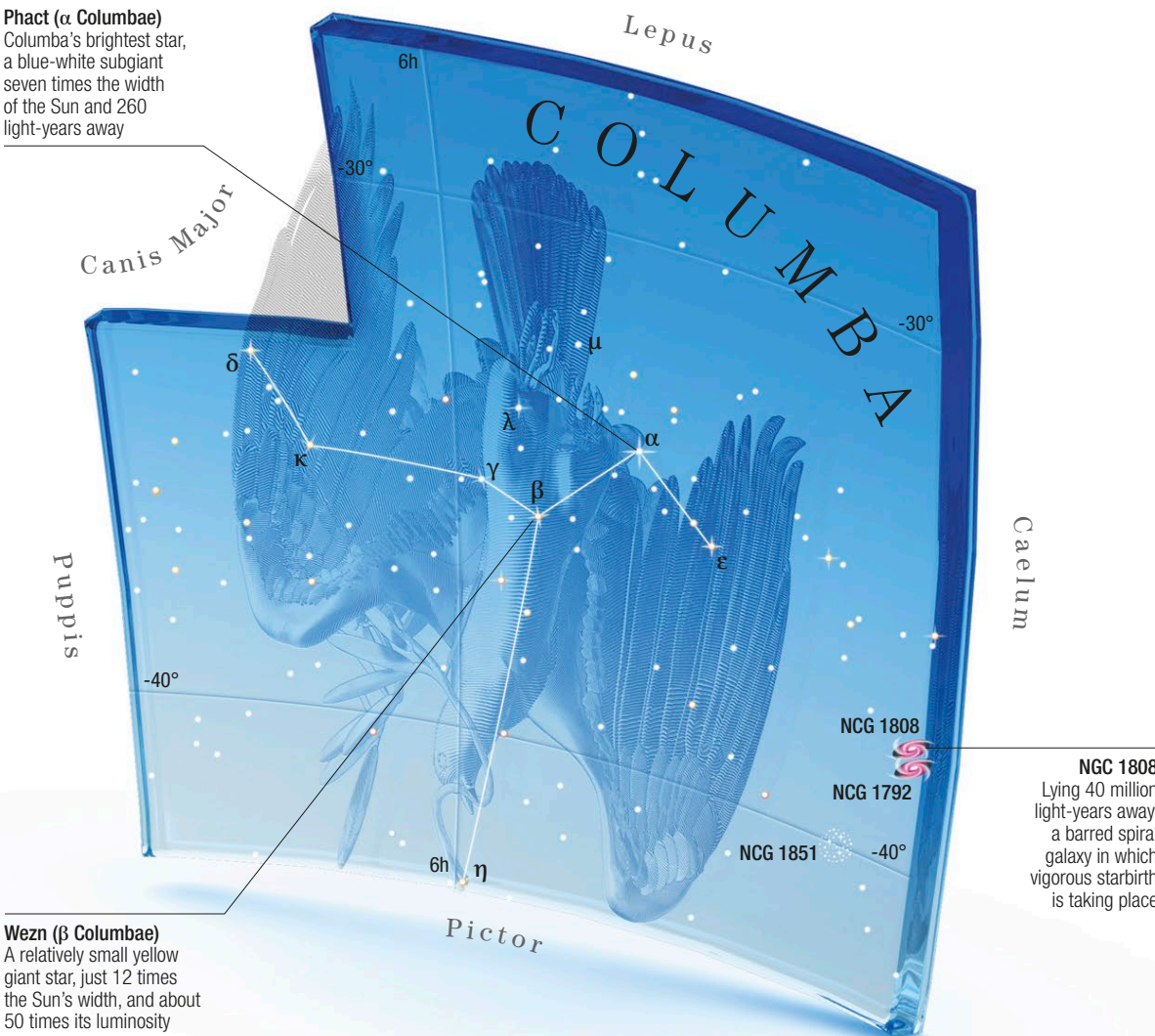
DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 1792
Spiral galaxy

NGC 1808
Barred spiral galaxy, also a Seyfert galaxy

NGC 1851
Globular cluster

Phact (α Columbae)
Columba's brightest star, a blue-white subgiant seven times the width of the Sun and 260 light-years away



Wezn (β Columbae)
A relatively small yellow giant star, just 12 times the Sun's width, and about 50 times its luminosity

NGC 1808
Lying 40 million light-years away, a barred spiral galaxy in which vigorous starbirth is taking place